there.”

They walked to a bridge, stopping to look at the water reflecting the buildings on both banks. As Rose gazed at the reflections, she thought about Léa—with a sister, she never really felt alone. She imagined how hard it must be for André, whose siblings were all much younger, and he had learned of his father’s death by himself, so far from home. Crossing the bridge, they entered a park and settled on a stone bench bordered by boxwood hedges. It was a beautiful, peaceful place, and for a moment, the war seemed far away.

“Are you still drawing?” He looked at her with what appeared to be hope flickering in his eyes.

“A little. I’ve been sketching portraits of Polish and Russian female workers.”

“That’s wonderful, Rose,” he said. “I still remember your stunning portrait of Léa. I’d like to see more.” He took her hand. “It’s mostly Russians at Tempelhof—three barracks for men and eight for women.”

“How are they treated?” She could guess the answer, but she held out hope that maybe in Berlin, people would be more open and accepting.

“I hardly see them. Their barracks sit behind ours, but they keep them separate in a subcamp with a guardhouse and trenches to prevent them from escaping.” He sighed. “I’d do anything to get out of Berlin before the bombing raids get worse, but I can’t see how.” He took a breath. “I fear I’ll end up buried under the rubble.”

“Don’t say that.” She touched his face, letting her hand linger on his cheek.

“How else will the war end?”

“There are signs for bomb shelters everywhere. You’ll be safe in one.” The memory of that horrible night in Orléans, when she and Léa huddled together while the Luftwaffe bombed the city, flashed through her mind. She squeezed his hand, trying to ease his fear.

“They don’t let foreign workers into the shelters. When the planes come—sometimes once a week, other times nightly—it’s endless. RAF bombers buzz overhead, hundreds at a time, and the sky flashes with fire. The roar swallows everything. Compared to here, Orléans was just sparks. This is a nightmare. We watch it happen, rooted in fear, daring to cheer as each blast pounds in our chests. We pray we won’t be hit next.”